The Civilization Guide to the Galaxy

Being a field manual to the principal life-forms found in any ledger

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Don't Panic.

— The Guide

To the Reader

The Galaxy is full of civilizations, and they are almost all described wrongly. They are described by their monuments—the pyramids, the aqueducts, the codes of law—which is rather like describing a restaurant by its chandelier. This Guide's editors, after extensive litigation and one mild bankruptcy, have reduced the whole science to a single principle: **a civilization is not what it builds; it is the ledger of what its inhabitants give to and take from one another.**

The entries below are the principal life-forms found in any ledger, ranked by nothing in particular. Most species meet them in the order listed, which is also the order in which they cease to be. The Guide takes no position on which of them deserves to win. It has noticed, however, that most of them have read the Guide, and that this has not improved the situation for anyone except the ones who were already winning.

The Producer

Also known as: the Host, the Bottom Layer, Those Who Give, the Base of the Pyramid.
Contents: one body, N hours per day, unlimited exposure to everyone above.
Rating: indispensable. Historically, also expendable.
Hazard to self: extinction by arithmetic.

The Producer generates the surplus on which every other entry feeds. They give labour, time, goods, attention, and loyalty; they receive a share set by others. The Theory's contribution to their self-understanding is unflattering but precise: **the heaviest extraction falls on those who can neither leave nor combine**—which is to say, on them, until they can.

What the insight affords Producers:

1. **Visibility.** They are almost always the "missing" party of the affected-set test—the ones whose thresholds are moved by relations to which they were never invited. Naming this is their first technology, and the cheapest.
2. **The real lever.** Their asset is the work, and the ability to withdraw it. The general strike is the only weapon that requires no capital and no arms. The Theory predicts it works exactly to the degree that coordination is made cheap.
3. **The chain test.** The peasant is not taxed by the emperor. He is taxed by everyone between himself and the emperor. Knowing where the leakage happens is knowing whom to negotiate with—and whom to remove.

Guide's note. The Producer rarely appears in the Guide's own index. The editors acknowledge the irony and have referred the matter to a subcommittee, which is a Producer.

The Short-Horizon Predator

Also known as: the Raider, the Locust, the Coup, the One-Quarters Profit.
Contents: one appetite, no patience.
Rating: extinguished. Average lifespan: brief and loud.
Hazard to self: guaranteed.

The Short-Horizon Predator discounts the future so heavily that the Theory's main payoff—conserve the host—is wasted on it. What it can still use: the exit ceiling (how hard to push before production stops), the affected-set blind spot (externalise onto the unrepresented), and hub-targeting (the cheapest way to fell a rival network). What it cannot use is patience, because conserving is a bet on a tomorrow it does not value.

The race result condemns it regardless of intent: its peers hunt the same host, so each undermines the host for all. It must monopolise or die—which is advice to stop being what it is.

Mostly harmless to the Galaxy. Fatal to its neighbourhood.

The Long-Horizon Predator

Also known as: the State, the Dynasty, the Platform, the Sophisticated Elite.
Contents: one host, conserved; one horizon, extended by institutions.
Rating: durable. Possibly permanent.
Hazard to self: the cascade, and only the cascade.

The Long-Horizon Predator is the Theory's true audience, and its most dangerous one. The insight is a **conservation and stabilisation manual**: extract at the sustainable ceiling; stay in the parasitic band; conserve the host; monopolise the race; lengthen your own horizon with succession rules, courts, and credible commitments; provision legitimacy—or substitute surveillance where belief cannot be produced; raise the coordination cost of the organised opposition to lift the ceiling; run jubilees as maintenance, not concession; reinforce the hubs so that no single failure becomes everyone's. The endpoint is a **low-legitimacy equilibrium**: stable, and not legitimate.

Guide's note. This is the entry most likely to be reading the Guide. It has purchased the Guide in bulk and issued it to its accountants. The editors are aware of the irony and have taken steps. The steps were not sufficient.

The Parasite

Also known as: the Rentier, the Guild, the Middleman, the Forty-Seven Regional Vice-Presidents.
Contents: small numbers, high organisation, concentrated benefits, diffuse costs.
Rating: comfortable, until abruptly it isn't.
Hazard to self: the empty core.

The Parasite lives within the band. Its advantage is the Theory's oldest finding: **voice is cheap for the small and organised.** The insight affords it a clear strategy—stay small, stay organised, stay mobile; keep the centre weak enough not to absorb you but strong enough to enforce the

contracts you depend on; conserve your host, because a smart parasite is a conservationist, and if you let the band tip into predation your income dies with it.

Its chief enemy is the **standing principle**. Extend the affected set and its externalised costs are internalised and its take falls. Expect the Parasite, therefore, to resist representation with every tool it owns—which is exactly what the Theory predicts.

Guide's note. The Parasite is the standing reason the core can empty. An empty core is how a Parasite becomes an *ex*-Parasite. See the next entry.

The Idealist Seeking Symbiosis

Also known as: the Reformer, the Organiser, the Reader of This Guide Who Nonetheless Intends to Do Something.

Contents: one theory of justice, one inconvenient map of why it usually loses.

Rating: correct. Usually late.

Hazard to self: success.

The Idealist is the most usable and least flattering entry. The Theory hands them five instruments.

1. **Visibility.** Measure the ledger; run the affected-set test; make structural injustice legible where moral language is ignored.
2. **The binding constraint is coordination, not conviction.** Emancipation is not won by being right. Build the union, the party, the cooperative, the network—the machinery that turns many actors into one.
3. **Enlarge the core.** A nonempty core means reform is possible and cheaper than collapse; extend standing and internalise externalities to convert a revolutionary situation into a reformable one.
4. **Respect the overstretch law.** Large voluntary symbiosis is bounded by productivity and coordination friction. Scale is not free.
5. **Watch the failure modes.** Captured legitimacy, settlements that are merely truces, and collapse concentrated in hubs.

Guide's warning. The successful Idealist becomes a Parasite. This is not a moral failing. It is the Theory. Plan accordingly; the alternative is to be a failed Idealist, which the Theory also predicts.

The Guide's Closing Observation

The Theory is **neutral**. It does not say who should win. It equalises information and lets existing capacity decide—which is a polite way of saying it mostly helps whoever can already act, and has now read the manual. Institutions convert short-horizon predators into long-horizon ones; races push parasites toward predation; reform pulls them toward symbiosis; and prosperity manufactures new parasites from old Idealists.

The one force the Theory says genuinely *reallocates* power is the coordination technology—the machinery that lets the many act as one. Build some. Defend it. Everyone in the entries above now knows exactly why it frightens them.

Mostly Harmless. Mostly.

And, as ever: bring a towel. The host is not optional.